

Unit 2 assessment

Unit summary

Professional ethics are the shared standards of conduct that come with a professional position. They are neither personal morality, which is private and varies legitimately, nor the law, which sets a floor rather than a standard. Teaching needs such an ethic because the gap between teacher and pupil is large, permanent and impossible for the pupil to escape, and because the harm of a bad decision often becomes visible only years later. Trust is the working capital that makes teaching possible, and it is extended at once by pupils, parents, the state and colleagues.

A code of ethical conduct states what is owed and to whom, organised by party: students; one's own practice and performance; parents and the community; colleagues and the profession. Codes exist at international, national and school level and are read together. But a code is a summary of settled judgement rather than a decision procedure, and it is silent on most of what a teacher does.

Where the code runs out, two models take over. Rest's four-component model holds that ethical action requires sensitivity, judgement, motivation and character, and that failure at any one produces the same visible result by a different route, requiring a different remedy. The four-step framework, Empathy, Context, Reflect and Action, is the working procedure, drawn as a loop so that reviewing the decision is part of making it.

A genuine dilemma is a conflict between obligations you actually hold. Grading dilemmas turn on separating the mark, which is a claim about the work, from the response, which is where care operates. Confidentiality is real and bounded, and the bound is stated in advance. Social media carries the classroom's power imbalance into a new medium. Equity dilemmas are hardest, and the working test is whether your reason could be stated openly to the class and to the parents.

Summative assessment

Multiple-choice questions (MCQs)

1. Professional ethics differ from the law chiefly because the law: (*Understand*)
a) applies only to employees of the state b) sets out what is intolerable rather than what is good c) is written down whereas ethics are not d) changes more often than professional standards
2. A teacher reads pupils' marks aloud in rank order. No rule forbids it. This is best described as: (*Apply*) a) a legal breach b) a failure of personal morality only c) a professional-ethics failure that no written rule reaches d) acceptable, since no rule was broken
3. Which feature of the teacher-pupil relationship most distinguishes it from a doctor-patient relationship? (*Understand*) a) The teacher is paid by the state b) The pupil cannot leave and cannot meaningfully consent c) The teacher has more subject knowledge d) The relationship lasts a fixed term
4. Copying forward unmarked scripts from last term belongs to which domain of a code of conduct? (*Remember*) a) Conduct toward students b) Conduct in practice and performance c) Conduct toward parents and community d) Conduct toward colleagues
5. Telling a parent only that "your son does not work" fails chiefly because the statement is: (*Understand*) a) untrue in every respect b) a breach of confidentiality c) accurate enough to feel honest but useless to act on d) too technical for a parent to follow
6. In Pakistan, the National Accreditation Council for Teacher Education relates to teacher ethics chiefly by: (*Remember*) a) publishing its own separate code of ethics b) accrediting programmes against the National Professional Standards for Teachers c) enforcing service rules in individual schools d) issuing teaching licences directly to individuals
7. A teacher notices nothing wrong when a pupil is repeatedly excluded from group work. In Rest's model this is a failure of: (*Understand*) a) moral sensitivity b) moral judgement c) moral motivation d) moral character

8. A teacher knows what is right, intends to act, and lets the moment pass at a staff meeting. This is a failure of: (*Apply*) a) moral sensitivity b) moral judgement c) moral character d) professional knowledge
9. The four-step framework is drawn as a loop rather than a line in order to: (*Understand*) a) show that the steps may be taken in any order b) make reviewing the outcome part of the decision itself c) indicate that dilemmas have no resolution d) show that Action is the least important step
10. Which of the following is a genuine ethical dilemma rather than a temptation? (*Understand*) a) A teacher is offered money to alter a mark b) A teacher must choose between reporting a grieving pupil's plagiarism and protecting her at a fragile moment c) A teacher considers arriving late because the class is tiring d) A teacher wonders whether to mark a relative's child generously

Restricted-response questions (RRQs)

1. In no more than 80 words, distinguish professional ethics from personal morality, and give one teaching example that belongs to the first and not the second. (*Understand*)
2. Explain why the delayed and invisible nature of harm in teaching strengthens the case for a shared professional ethic rather than individual conscience. (*Analyze*)
3. Explain what is meant by describing trust as the "working capital" of a teacher's authority, and name two of the four parties who extend it. (*Understand*)
4. Name the four domains a code of ethical conduct organises obligations by, and give one example breach in each. (*Remember*)
5. Explain why assessment honesty is an ethical obligation rather than an administrative one. Refer to who bears the cost of a false mark. (*Understand*)
6. A colleague argues that a written code is pointless because it cannot cover every situation. Set out what is correct in the observation and explain why

the conclusion does not follow. (*Analyze*)

7. State Rest's four components in order and give, for each, the one remedy most likely to help a teacher who fails there. (*Remember*)
8. Distinguish a failure of moral sensitivity from a failure of moral motivation, and state what evidence would allow an observer to tell them apart. (*Analyze*)
9. Explain the distinction between the mark and the response, and apply it to a pupil whose work is weak because of severe family hardship. (*Apply*)
10. Rewrite the promise "you can tell me anything" into a statement about confidentiality that a teacher can actually keep, and explain in one sentence why the original cannot be kept. (*Apply*)

Extended-response questions (ERQs)

1. "Following the rules and keeping a clear conscience is all anyone can ask of a teacher." Evaluate this claim, using the distinction between law, personal morality and professional ethics, and at least one worked classroom example of your own. (*Evaluate*)
2. Analyse the Mr Aslam vignette from Topic 2.2 across all four domains of a code of conduct. For each failure, identify the domain, the person harmed, and the time scale over which the harm becomes visible. Conclude by arguing which failure a school is least likely to detect, and why. (*Analyze*)
3. Using Rest's four-component model, explain why increasing teachers' knowledge of what is right is an incomplete strategy for improving ethical conduct in a school. Propose one practical measure for each of the three components that instruction does not address. (*Create*)
4. Take a classroom dilemma involving equity, in which treating pupils identically would produce an unfair outcome. Work it through the four-step framework, reach a decision, and defend it against the objection that you have shown favouritism. (*Evaluate*)
5. **Integrative.** A teacher discovers that a colleague has been inflating the marks of pupils whose families pay for private tuition with that colleague.

The teacher has strong but circumstantial evidence, no formal authority, and a good working relationship with the colleague.

Work this situation through **both** Rest's four-component model and the four-step framework. Then argue which of the two produced the more useful guidance in this particular case, and explain what that tells you about what each model is for. (*Evaluate*)

Answers and marking guidance

MCQ answer key

1. **b** - the law marks the boundary of the punishable; ethics describes good practice above it.
2. **c** - no rule is breached and the teacher means well, which is precisely the gap professional ethics occupies.
3. **b** - the pupil's inability to exit or consent is the structural difference; subject knowledge (c) is common to both.
4. **b** - it is a failure of competent, honest practice, not of kindness toward the pupil.
5. **c** - the statement's uselessness, not its falsity, is the failure; it gives the parent nothing to act on.
6. **b** - NACTE accredits against the National Professional Standards rather than issuing a separate ethics code.
7. **a** - the teacher never perceived an ethical situation, so judgement was never engaged.
8. **c** - sensitivity, judgement and motivation all succeeded; follow-through failed.
9. **b** - the return arrow makes the review of the outcome part of the procedure.
10. **b** - only (b) sets two genuine obligations against each other; (a), (c) and (d) are temptations with an obvious right answer.

RRQ model answers and mark schemes

1. **(4 marks)** Professional ethics are shared, storable standards attaching to a professional role (1); personal morality is private, self-formed and legitimately

variable (1); the example belongs to the role rather than the person (1); the example is a genuine gap case rather than a rule breach (1).

2. (4 marks) Names the delay between act and visible harm (1); explains that the pupil cannot connect the two events and so cannot hold the teacher to account (1); concludes that accountability cannot rest on the affected party (1); links this to why a shared, external standard is required (1).

3. (4 marks) Trust is accumulated slowly through ordinary reliable acts (1); it is spent invisibly and destroyed fast (1); without it a teacher can compel behaviour but not produce learning, because learning requires risking being wrong (1); names two of pupils, parents, state, colleagues (1).

4. (8 marks) One mark per domain correctly named (4); one mark per apt example breach (4). Examples must sit in the domain claimed.

5. (4 marks) States that a mark is a public claim relied on by others (1); names who bears the cost, including other pupils and any body acting on the mark (1); distinguishes this from a private matter between teacher and pupil (1); identifies the shortcut justification and rejects it (1).

6. (5 marks) Concedes accurately that codes are general, self-conflicting and silent on most situations (2); explains that a code is a summary of settled judgement, not an exhaustive prohibition list (1); argues that incompleteness is an argument for judgement alongside a code, not against having one (2).

7. (8 marks) Sensitivity, judgement, motivation, character, in order (4). Remedies: practice in reading situations; codes, principles and worked cases; honest reckoning with competing values and institutional support; rehearsal, allies and advance commitment (4).

8. (5 marks) Sensitivity failure means the ethical dimension was never perceived (1); motivation failure means it was perceived and judged but outweighed (1); evidence distinguishing them includes whether the teacher can describe the situation accurately afterwards (1), whether they show discomfort at the time (1), and whether they have acted on similar cases before (1).

9. (5 marks) The mark is a claim about the work and is not the teacher's to trade (2); the response is everything else the teacher does and is where care

operates (2); applies both to the hardship case without collapsing one into the other (1).

10. (3 marks) Rewrite states a limit tied to risk of harm (1); promises to tell the pupil first (1); explains that an unlimited promise must be broken in precisely the cases that matter most (1).

ERQ rubrics

Each ERQ is marked out of 20 on the four criteria below. A response that does not reach "Adequate" on the analysis criterion cannot be awarded more than 10 overall, whatever its other merits.

ERQ 1 - Evaluating the "rules and clear conscience" claim

Criterion	Limited (1-2)	Adequate (3)	Strong (4-5)
Command of the three-way distinction	Conflates law and ethics	Distinguishes all three	Shows precisely what each fails to reach
Quality of example	Generic or a plain rule-breach	Concrete classroom example	Example genuinely occupies the gap
Evaluative reasoning (Analyze or higher)	Asserts a verdict	Argues a verdict with reasons	Takes the claim at its strongest, then shows why a clear conscience is insufficient evidence
Structure and register	Disorganised	Clear	Written for a colleague, economical

ERQ 2 - Four-domain analysis of Mr Aslam

Criterion	Limited (1-2)	Adequate (3)	Strong (4-5)
Domain assignment	Two or more misassigned	All four correct	Correct, with the overlap of the staff-room remark noticed
Harm identified	Named only in general terms	Person and harm named	Harm traced over time, including who never learns of it
Analysis of detectability	Asserts which is least detectable	Gives a reason	Explains detectability from the structure of the domain, not the severity of the act
Use of evidence	No reference to any code	Refers to a code	Refers accurately to a specific standard or domain

ERQ 3 - Rest's model and school strategy

Criterion	Limited (1-2)	Adequate (3)	Strong (4-5)
Grasp of the model	Components confused	All four correct	Shows why failure at any one yields the same visible result
Diagnosis of the gap	States that instruction is incomplete	Identifies which component it addresses	Explains why the other three are untouched by instruction
Proposed measures (Create)	Vague or generic	One workable measure per component	Measures are specific, school-level, and matched to the

Criterion	Limited (1-2)	Adequate (3)	Strong (4-5)
			failure mode rather than interchangeable
Realism	Ignores constraints	Acknowledges them	Measures survive the constraints named

ERQ 4 - An equity dilemma

Criterion	Limited (1-2)	Adequate (3)	Strong (4-5)
Framing as a dilemma	Treats it as right vs wrong	Names both goods	Shows why identical treatment is both defensible and unfair here
Use of the framework	Steps skipped or merged	All four completed	Context establishes facts rather than restating the problem
Defence against favouritism (Evaluate)	Dismisses the objection	Answers it	Distinguishes adjusting conditions from adjusting the standard and applies the public-reason test
Specificity of decision	Sentiment only	Actionable decision	Another teacher could carry it out unchanged

ERQ 5 - Integrative: the colleague inflating marks

Criterion	Limited (1-2)	Adequate (3)	Strong (4-5)
Application of Rest	Listed, not applied	Applied to the case	Locates precisely where this teacher is most likely to fail and why
Application of the framework	Steps asserted	Worked through	Context handles the evidential weakness honestly rather than assuming guilt
Comparison of the two models (Evaluate)	States a preference	Justifies a preference	Explains what each model is for - diagnosis versus procedure - and shows why this case favours one
Handling of uncertainty	Treats suspicion as proof	Notes the evidence is circumstantial	Builds a course of action appropriate to circumstantial evidence, including what would confirm it

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

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